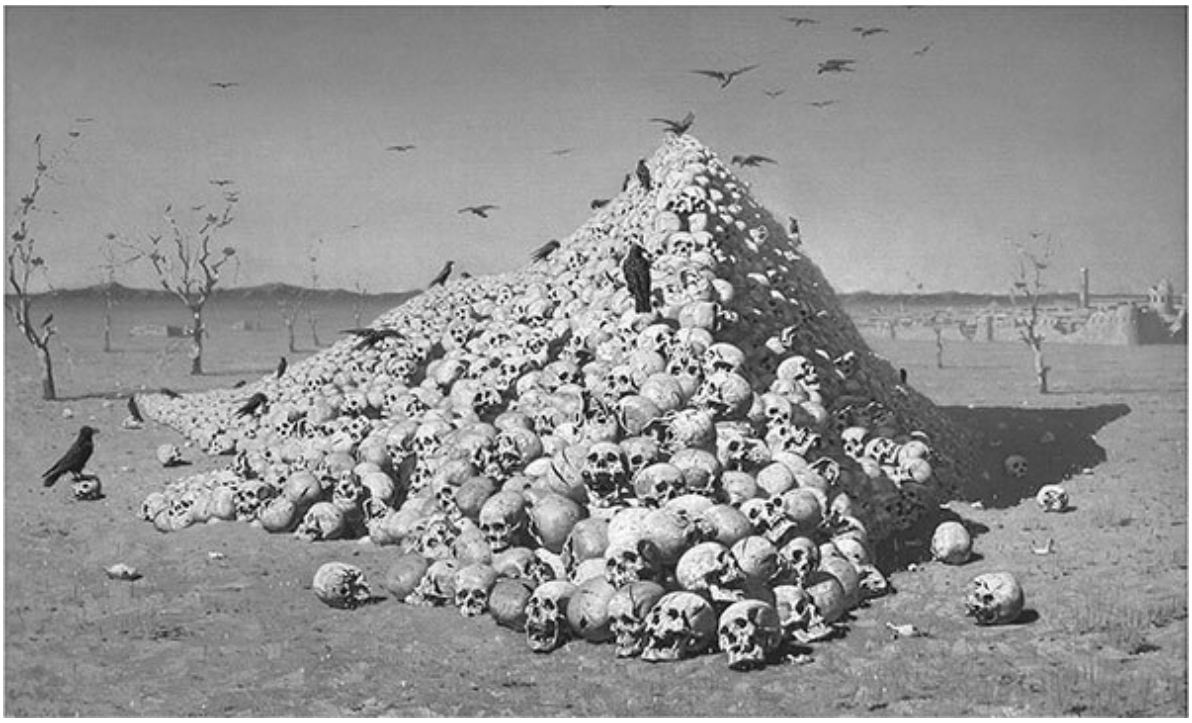


Figure 3: The Apotheosis of War, 1871. Anti-war painting depicting a pyramid of skulls made by the fourteenth-century ruler Timur. From the Tretyakov Gallery, Moscow. (Vereshchagin, 1871).

He writes, ‘We had been told that when Afghāns are powerless to resist, they go before their foe with grass between their teeth, this being as much as to say, “I am your cow.”’ And this is exactly what happened on the ground. When Afghāns failed to resist, they came to Babur with grass between their teeth. But Babur chose not to show mercy. They were brought in as prisoners and beheaded one by one. The heads were piled up in a tower.

This custom is a Tīmūrid practice. Timur was known to make towers of skulls. In AD 1402, at Smyrna, all civilians were beheaded by him, and two massive towers of heads were erected. Back in AD 1388, as retaliation to inhabitants’ rebellion against the tax collectors, he compiled thirty such towers and each is reported to have contained around fifteen hundred heads.[*]

They camped right there, and on the next day, began to march forward, finally dismounting at Hangū. The local Afghāns had made a *sanger* on a hill. Babur has penned his thoughts about sanger:

> I first heard the word sanger after coming to Kābul where people describe fortifying themselves on a hill as making a sanger.

The Tīmūrids slaughtered again. Babur’s men went straight up, broke into the sanger, and chopped off around 200 ‘insolent’ Afghān heads. Just like Timur, Babur made a tower of heads.